

TCU - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG 12

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Above-average Power 4 / top-third Big 12 quality on paper, but with unusually high implementation risk because TCU replaces its established quarterback.
Preseason consensus	others receiving votes (11 votes/points) · No. 32
Returning production	51% (No. 71) overall · Off. 44% (No. 101) · Def. 58% (No. 45)
Primer power rating	+9.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	7.4 wins · most likely 7-5
Net vs. 2025	● ↓ - Slightly worse / more volatile despite a similar SP+ level: TCU keeps defensive building blocks.
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: Gordon Sammis is installing a new offense around transfer QB Jaden Craig, WR Jordan Dwyer and a rebuilt line, while Andy Avalos keeps a 4-2-5 built around a recognizable front and S Jamel Johnson in the secondary.

Bottom line: TCU has enough model strength and defensive front talent to remain a seven-to-eight-win contender, but the new QB/OC pairing, OL competitions and depleted secondary make the Horned Frogs less stable than their No. 32 SP+ ranking alone implies.

Beats expectations if: QB Jaden Craig translates quickly, OC Gordon Sammis protects the reshuffled line, and the returning front keeps a rebuilt secondary out of stress situations.

Disappoints if: The QB transition exposes the 44% offensive returning-production problem, center/right tackle never settle, and the secondary cannot absorb its major losses and unresolved roles.

Five things to remember

- 1 Quarterback:** QB Jaden Craig is the projected QB1 after QB Josh Hoover transferred, and he will run a newly installed Gordon Sammis offense.
- 2 National baseline:** TCU returns only 44% of offensive production (No. 101), so the offense's No. 30 SP+ projection carries meaningful newcomer/role risk.
- 3 ★ S Jamel Johnson:** S Jamel Johnson is the secondary anchor and the lone forced Players-to-Know recognition player, but the safety/nickel plan changed after Jacob Fields' dismissal.
- 4 ? Key uncertainty:** DB Austin Jordan is not settled roster depth; his 2026 roster/eligibility status and whether he pursued professional football remain unresolved.
- 5 Schedule pressure:** The schedule closes brutally: Arizona, Kansas State, Utah and Texas Tech in the final four games, with the last game in Lubbock.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	9-4 (5-4 Big 12)	● Good
Scoring	30.7 PPG	● Good / above average
Total offense	421.5 YPG	● Very good
Rush offense	131.4 YPG · 3.9 YPC	● Below average
Pass efficiency	8.20 YPA · 30 TD / 15 INT	● Very good
Third downs	47.4%	● Elite
Scoring defense	25.3 PPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Total defense	378.7 YPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Rush defense	133.1 YPG · 3.7 YPC	● Good / above average
Pass defense	245.6 YPG · 7.51 YPA · 25 TD allowed	● Below average

TCU’s offense was the stronger raw unit: total offense No. 27, pass efficiency No. 24 and third downs No. 15, while the run game ranked No. 100. The defense was middling in scoring/yardage (No. 72/73) and especially vulnerable in pass-efficiency defense (No. 88).

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+3.62 · No. 38	● Good / above average
Off. EPA/play	+0.086 · No. 35	● Very good
Off. success rate	45.1% · No. 43	● Good / above average
Off. explosive-play rate	12.0% · No. 69	● Average / mixed
Havoc allowed	15.3% · No. 73	● Average / mixed
Opp.-adjusted defense	+3.96 · No. 30	● Very good
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.070 · No. 39	● Good / above average
Def. success rate allowed	40.7% · No. 57	● Average / mixed
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	10.8% · No. 41	● Good / above average
Havoc created	14.1% · No. 103	● Below average

Advanced-stat read: TCU’s 2025 underlying profile was better than the raw defensive yardage suggests: adjusted offense No. 38 and adjusted defense No. 30, with EPA/play ranks No. 35 and No. 39.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Sonny Dykes - returning	● ↔ Sonny Dykes' return preserves the overall program identity through an offensive coordinator change.
OC / play-caller	◆ Gordon Sammis - new external OC; offensive play-caller	● ↔ A new play-caller creates schematic upside, but early offensive execution is a transition variable.
DC / scheme owner	Andy Avalos - returning DC; exact game-day caller unresolved	● ↔ Andy Avalos keeps defensive scheme continuity, though the exact game-day caller remains unresolved.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Jaden Craig	Harvard	● ↔ Projected QB1 replacing a three-year starter; credible option.
◆ WR Jeremy Scott	South Alabama	● ↔ Expected first-unit Z receiver in a room replacing multiple veteran/pro departures.
◆ RB Landon Walker	Colorado School of Mines	● ↔ Major rotation option behind Jeremy Payne after RB Kevorian Barnes and RB Trent Battle departed.
◆ OL Noah McKinney / Jaheim Buchanan	Oklahoma State / FIU	● ↔ McKinney projects first at RG while OL Buchanan is in the center competition.

Out	To	Loss
QB Josh Hoover	Indiana	● ↓ Three-year starting quarterback leaves, creating the offense's biggest continuity loss.
WR Joseph Manjack IV	NFL (Denver), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Material 2025 receiver departs via confirmed college-free-agent path.
RB Kevorian Barnes / Trent Battle	New York Giants / Atlanta Falcons	● ↓ Two material 2025 backs depart through confirmed UDFA paths.
OL Coltin Deery / Carson Bruno / Remington Strickland	NFL opportunity / eligibility	● ↓ Multiple veteran 2025 linemen leave, contributing directly to the live center/right-tackle competitions.

Offensive net: ● ↓ clear downgrade in continuity with enough transfer talent to remain functional

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ LB Michael Short	Virginia Tech	● ↔ Projected first-unit MLB replacing major veteran linebacker losses.
◆ EDGE Koron Hayward / Cheta Ofili	Western Kentucky / Texas Tech	● ↔ Adds rotation depth around returning EDGE Paul Oyewale.
◆ CB Kalen Carroll	Central Michigan	● ↔ Rotation addition for a secondary replacing substantial 2025 experience.

Out	To	Loss
S Bud Clark	NFL (Seattle), Round 2, No. 64	● ↓ Second-round safety departure removes a major back-end anchor.
LB Kaleb Elarms-Orr / Namdi Obiazor	Elarms-Orr: NFL (Buffalo), Round 4, No. 126; Obiazor: NFL (New England), Round 6, No. 212	● ↓ Two drafted linebackers depart, forcing a significant second-level reset.
CB Channing Canada	NFL (New England), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Material corner departs via confirmed UDFA path.
S Jacob Fields	Dismissed for team-rules violation	● ↓ Dismissal removes a planned secondary piece.

Defensive net: ● ↓ slight downgrade with a stable front but substantial back-seven turnover

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	New OC Gordon Sammis attack with transfer QB Jaden Craig and a rebuilt line.	Skill talent and a credible projected five can preserve balance if QB Jaden Craig translates.	QB, play-caller and veteran OL/skill turnover; only 44% offensive returning production.
Defense	DC Andy Avalos' 4-2-5 built around EDGE Paul Oyewale and DL Markis Deal.	Adjusted defense was No. 30 and the front returns multiple first-unit pieces.	Major LB/secondary losses plus No. 103 havoc creation.
Special teams	New punter plus open placekicker competition.	P Chance carries Ray Guy recognition and is the high-confidence projected punter.	Kicker remains unsettled and SP+ special teams is No. 87.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B-	● ↓	Medium-low	QB Jaden Craig is the projected starter but must translate from Harvard.
RB	● B-	● ↓	Medium	RB Jeremy Payne leads a room replacing two professional departures.
WR	● B-	● ↓	Medium	WR Jordan Dwyer leads a room replacing veteran production.
TE	● B-	● ↔	Medium-high	TE Ka'Morreun Pimpton provides useful returning continuity.
OL	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	Veteran losses leave center and right tackle unsettled.
DL/Edge	● B	● ↔	Medium-high	DL Ansel Din-Mbuh and EDGE Paul Oyewale anchor a stable front.
LB	● B-	● ↓	Medium	LB Michael Short enters after two drafted linebackers depart.
Secondary	● B-	● ↓	Medium-low	S Jamel Johnson anchors a back end with major losses and unresolved depth.
Special teams	● C+	● ↓	Medium	P John Hoyet Chance is settled; kicker remains open.
Coaching	● B	● ↓	Medium	New OC/play-caller Gordon Sammis adds implementation risk.
Overall	● B	● ↓	Medium-low	Top-third Big 12 talent with unusually high offensive-transition risk.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters	
Jamel Johnson	S	● High-end Big 12 safety	Big 12 Preseason Team: first team · Bednarik Award · Bronko Nagurski Trophy · Jim Thorpe Award	Forced Players-to-Know recognition player and the stabilizing star in a secondary with major turnover.	r.
Jaden Craig	QB	● Upside transfer starter	-	Projected QB1 replacing Josh Hoover.	
Jordan Dwyer	WR	● Potential lead receiver	Biletnikoff Award	Current X/leading-receiver projection and the most recognized offensive skill player.	
Ben Taylor-Whitfield	OL	● Key veteran tackle	Outland Trophy	Projected LT and one of the few recognized continuity pieces on a reshuffled line.	
Ansel Din-Mbuh	DT	● High-end interior lineman	Outland Trophy	First-unit DT and one of the strongest anchors in Avalos' four-man front.	
Paul Oyewale	EDGE	● Returning edge anchor	-	Confirmed same-school return and projected first-unit edge after earlier portal noise.	
Ka'Morreun Pimpton	TE	● Key returning tight end	-	Confirmed same-school return and current TE1, providing useful continuity amid offensive turnover.	

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
John Hoyet Chance	P	● Recognized punter	Ray Guy Award	Projected punter and the strongest settled part of an otherwise uncertain special-teams unit.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Moderately difficult and back-loaded; TCU gets two manageable home games after the Dublin opener.
Difficulty	● 6/10 · SP+ SOS No. 42
Hardest stretch	at Arizona -> Kansas State -> Utah -> at Texas Tech (Nov. 6-26)
Swing games	BYU, at Baylor, at Arizona, Kansas State, Utah
Advantage	A Sept. 5 bye follows the Ireland opener, and an Oct. 10 bye precedes the rivalry trip to Baylor.
Expected	7.4 wins · likely 7-5
Floor / ceiling	5-7 / 9-3

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	TCU's No. 32 SP+ signal and 9-4 brand can support favorite pricing, but the QB translation risk may be overstated if the new run-game structure keeps QB Jaden Craig efficient instead of asking him to reproduce Josh Hoover's passing volume.
Back them when	Prefer TCU when the front can control the matchup and the price does not demand immediate high-end passing efficiency from QB Craig.
Fade/pass when	Fade or pass when opponents can stress the unsettled OL or isolate the rebuilt secondary.
Key monitor	QB Jaden Craig transition, center/right tackle, nickel/safety alignment, DB Austin Jordan's unresolved status, placekicker
Week 1 baseline	TCU -6.0 vs. North Carolina (Dublin, neutral) · rating-only baseline; TCU primer +9.5 minus North Carolina primer +3.5; no home-field, matchup or availability adjustment. Compare with the live market before betting. Live market: TCU -7.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

TCU's strongest path is a credible defensive front buying time for a new offense. QB Jaden Craig, WR Jordan Dwyer and TE Ka'Morreun Pimpton give OC Gordon Sammis useful pieces, but the QB transition and unsettled center/right tackle spots create real implementation risk.

S Jamel Johnson anchors a secondary replacing major NFL production and adjusting after S Jacob Fields' dismissal, while DB Austin Jordan's status remains unresolved. The late schedule punishes slow development, making **7.4 wins and 7-5** a sensible baseline.

About this primer

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Sources: [projected depth chart](#) · [2026 roster](#) · [DL update](#) · [coaching update](#) · [NFL departures](#) · [Deseret News report](#) · [Frogs O' War report](#) · [ESPN / Pete Thamel report](#) · [Frogs O' War report](#) · [2026 Football Coaches](#)

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